imagines how they quietly prayed to God to perform some miracle, which failed to materialise. The poem then tells how even after the pogrom was over, the survivors had no thought of arming themselves and instead entered Talmudic disputations about whether the raped women were now ritualistically ‘defiled’ or whether they were still ‘pure’. This poem is mandatory reading in many Israeli schools today. It is also mandatory reading for anyone wishing to understand how after two millennia of being one of the most pacifist groups in history, Jews built one of the most formidable armies in the world. Not for nothing was Bialik named Israel’s national poet.[2]

The fact that Bialik lived in Ukraine, and was intimately familiar with the persecution of Ashkenazi Jews in eastern Europe but had little understanding of conditions in Palestine, contributed to the subsequent conflict there between Jews and Arabs. Bialik’s poems inspired Jews to see themselves as victims in dire need of developing their military might and building their own country, but hardly considered the catastrophic consequences for the Arab inhabitants of Palestine, or indeed for the Mizrahi Jewish communities native to the Middle East. When the Arab–Israeli conflict exploded in the late 1940s, hundreds of thousands of Palestinians and hundreds of thousands of Mizrahi Jews were driven out of their ancestral homes in the Middle East, partly as a result of poems composed half a century earlier in Ukraine.[3]

While Bialik was writing in Ukraine, the Hungarian Jew Theodor Herzl was busy organising the Zionist movement in the 1890s and early years of the twentieth century. As a central part of his political activism, Herzl published two books. *The Jewish State* (1896) was a manifesto outlining Herzl’s idea of establishing a Jewish state in Palestine, and *The Old New Land* (1902) was a utopian novel set in the year 1923 describing the prosperous Jewish state that Herzl envisioned. The two books – which fatefully also tended to ignore realities on the ground in Palestine – were immensely influential in shaping the Zionist movement. *The Old New Land* appeared in Hebrew under the title *Tel Aviv* (a loose Hebrew translation of ‘Old New Land’). The city of Tel Aviv, established seven years after the book’s publication, took its name from the book. While Bialik is Israel’s national poet, Herzl is known as the visionary of the state.

The yarns Bialik and Herzl wove ignored many crucial facts about contemporary reality, most notably that around 1900 the Jews of Palestine